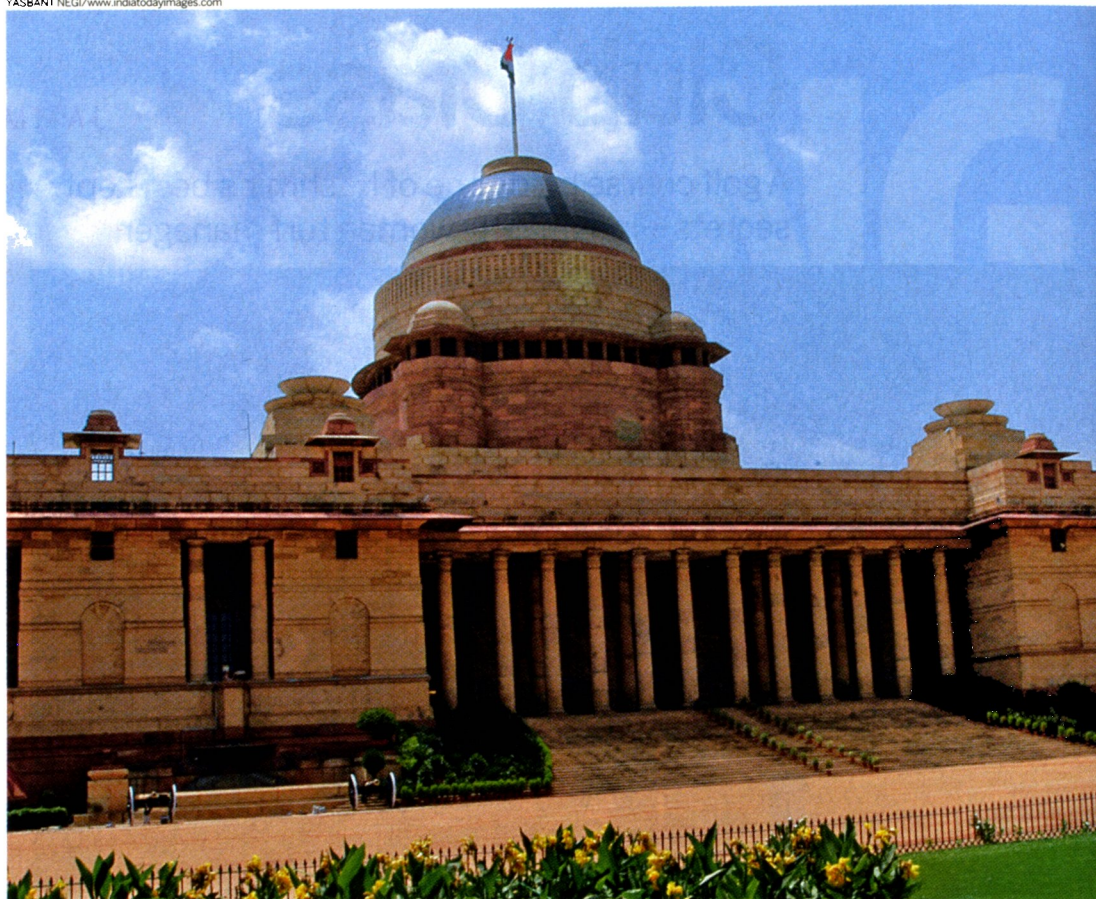
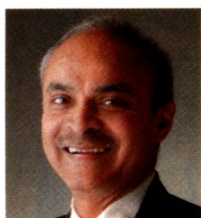




DELHI | A World of Honour

The Padma awards have always been meant to recognise the country's home-grown talent in fields ranging from science to the arts. Yet, the 2010 list of Republic Day honours have for the first time reached across the globe—or at least to the Indo-centric global community—on an unprecedented scale. Given that five of the 43 Padma Bhushan awards have gone overseas, it's obvious that the Manmohan Singh Government realises the importance of the well-connected Indian. This year's Padma awards list clearly has the prime minister's seal of approval. The awardees include global Indians like Nobel Prize winner Dr. Venkatraman Ramakrishnan, controversial New York-based hotelier Sant Singh Chatwal, *Newsweek* Editor Fared Zakaria and Unilever chief Vindi Banga. With seven awardees from the US, it's clear that those who lobbied for the Indo-US nuclear deal have been duly recognised. Apart from artistes, doctors of prime ministers and Presidents are now regulars on this list—from Zail Singh's eye surgeon Dhanwant Singh to A.B. Vajpayee's knee doctor Chittaranjan Ranawat and now Manmohan's heart surgeon Ramakant Panda. Narendra Modi-baiters, danseuse Mallika Sarabhai and Thermax Chairperson Anu Agha, too have been felicitated. Sarabhai also contested against L.K. Advani in E-2009. This is a government that looks after its friends, both at home and overseas. **by Priya Sahgal**

(FROM TOP)
ZAKARIA,
RAMAKRISHNAN,
BANGA AND
CHATWAL;
RASHTRAPATI
BHAVAN

13

of the 130 Padma awardees are NRIs and foreigners, seven from the US alone. Clearly, the prime minister knows the importance of the well-connected Indian.